Helping others understand your contribution

Practical guide for students | D18-ST

When someone misinterprets your answer, clarify the meaning you intended. Your contribution may need a clearer explanation, and the listener may also need to check their interpretation. Both people contribute to understanding.

1. State the main point

Begin with the idea you want the listener to understand. Use a short sentence before adding detail. Keep important subject terms and relationships accurate.

2. Show the reasoning

Explain the relevant cause, step or evidence. Use a calculation, diagram or written keyword when it helps and is allowed. Make clear how it connects to your point.

3. Notice a possible misunderstanding

If the response does not match what you meant, pause and clarify. Try: “I may not have explained that clearly. The point I’m making is …” You can also ask what the listener understood.

4. Confirm or correct a paraphrase

If someone restates your idea, check whether the meaning is accurate. Say what is right and correct the part that differs: “Yes, demand rises, but I meant that supply remains unchanged.”

5. Try another explanation

Repeat the key idea using a different example or a clearer sequence. If you do not know a word, describe the relationship and ask for the term. Do not agree with an interpretation that changes your meaning.

6. Check the shared understanding

Ask a focused check: “Is it clear that I’m comparing the two causes, rather than saying they are the same?” Use the response to decide whether more explanation is needed.

7. Example

You say a lower price could increase demand. A classmate assumes you predict higher profit. You clarify: “I’m only saying demand may rise. Profit also depends on the margin and costs.” You show these as separate points so the group can discuss the recommendation accurately.

8. Quick checklist

☐ My central point is clear.

☐ I have explained the reasoning.

☐ I correct interpretations that change my meaning.

☐ I use another explanation when needed.

9. When to seek further support

If you are repeatedly misunderstood, ask for specific feedback on one example. Your teacher or a language adviser can help identify whether the issue concerns meaning, structure, terminology or pronunciation. In assessment, clarification must follow the applicable rules.

10.Supporting sources

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Tips for communicating with international and multilingual students. Open resource

Educator guidance directly supports paraphrasing a student’s contribution, checking comprehension and allowing confirmation or correction.

University of Minnesota, College of Continuing & Professional Studies. (n.d.). Group Work/Projects. Open resource

Student guidance supports checking meaning, clarifying contributions and using questions during group discussion.